

GA-OP-03

Safeguarding of Resources & Equipment

Standards for the safe, responsible, and sustainable use, storage, movement, maintenance, and reporting of school resources and equipment.

APPLIES TO

Gardner Academy employees and relevant staff

AUTHORITY

Gardner Academy operational, safety, and property-management standard

01 Purpose and shared responsibility

School resources exist to support children, teaching, care, and operations. Every employee has a duty to use them safely, protect them from avoidable loss or damage, keep them available for their intended purpose, and report concerns promptly. This responsibility applies to classroom materials, furniture, tools, appliances, technology, sports and playground equipment, cleaning equipment, keys, vehicles, books, stock, and other school property.

02 Authorised and appropriate use

Employees must:

- Use resources and equipment only for their intended school purpose and within their training or authority.
- Follow operating instructions, safety guidance, age restrictions, and required supervision.
- Check that an item is suitable for the activity, environment, and children using it.
- Use protective equipment and safety controls where required.
- Obtain approval before lending, relocating, modifying, repairing, disposing of, or taking school property off site.
- Never permit personal, commercial, or unauthorised use of school resources.

03 Before and during use

Before use, staff should make a reasonable visual and functional check for damage, missing parts, contamination, instability, exposed wiring, sharp edges, expired materials, or another obvious hazard. During use, equipment must remain appropriately supervised and must not be overloaded, forced, bypassed, or used in a way that creates an avoidable risk. Students may use equipment only with developmentally appropriate instruction and supervision.

04 Unsafe, damaged, or malfunctioning equipment

If an item appears unsafe, damaged, incomplete, or unreliable: stop using it, prevent others from using it, clearly label or isolate it where possible, and report it promptly through the approved maintenance or management process. Do not make an improvised repair unless authorised and competent to do so. An urgent hazard must be reported immediately and the surrounding area secured until it is safe.

05 Storage and security

Resources must be returned clean, complete, and ready for the next user. Store equipment in its designated place, keep exits and access routes clear, lock restricted items and valuable equipment where required, and keep hazardous substances, medicines, chemicals, sharp tools, keys, and age-restricted resources inaccessible to students except during properly supervised use. Charging equipment and electrical items must be stored and used in a way that avoids heat, moisture, trip, and fire risks.

06 Sign-out, movement, and return

Items covered by an inventory, issue, booking, or sign-out process must be recorded accurately. The person receiving an item is responsible for its reasonable care and timely return, including all parts, cables, cases, keys, or accessories. Property may not be transferred to another employee, classroom, site, or external person without updating the record or notifying the responsible custodian.

07 Consumables and shared stock

Consumables must be used carefully and for approved work. Staff should take only what is reasonably needed, return reusable excess, avoid unnecessary duplication and waste, and notify the responsible person before essential stock runs out. Restricted, high-value, hazardous, or perishable stock must follow the applicable storage and issue controls. Resources reserved for a class, programme, student need, or department may not be redirected without permission.

Loss, damage, and incident reporting

Missing items, breakage, spills, faults, misuse, and safety incidents must be reported as soon as they are discovered. The report should state what happened, where and when it occurred, who was using or supervising the item, and what immediate action was taken. Honest reporting supports repair and prevention. Staff must not hide damage, discard evidence, alter records, blame a student without facts, or continue using an unsafe item. Theft or suspected theft must also be handled under the Theft, Suspected Theft & Protection of Property Policy.

Accountability

Employees must report ordinary wear, accidental damage, missing items, and mistakes honestly and promptly. Negligence, deliberate misuse, concealment, unauthorised repair or disposal, and repeated failure to follow instructions may result in coaching, retraining, or action under the applicable process. Employees must participate honestly in any follow-up and must not independently replace, pay for, or dispose of an item unless instructed through an approved process.